

Strategy Space

Breathing & Grounding Techniques

A calming toolkit for parents and teachers, using the BRIDGE Method

This resource sits inside **D — Design Matching Strategies**: simple, embodied tools you can teach a child before a hard moment happens, so they're already familiar by the time they're needed. Every technique here works the same way at home and at school, which is what makes it a BRIDGE tool rather than just a nice idea.

The one rule that matters most: teach and practise these when your child is calm, not in the middle of distress. A brand-new skill rarely works the first time it's tried under stress, but a well-practised one becomes automatic exactly when it's needed.

Star Breathing

A visual, tactile way to slow the breath down, using the shape of a star as a guide so a child has something concrete to follow.

How to do it

1. Trace a star in the air, on paper, or on a table, with a finger (yours, then theirs).
2. As the finger moves up one point of the star, breathe in slowly through the nose.
3. At the tip of the point, hold the breath for a moment.
4. As the finger traces down the other side of the point, breathe out slowly.
5. Continue point by point, all the way around the star.

Why it works

It gives a child's attention something to follow, so the breath slows down without needing to think about “breathing deeply” directly, which can be a hard instruction to follow when upset. The shape also makes it easy to practise as a game in calm moments, drawing stars, decorating one, or tracing it on a window.

Breathing With Your Child

The simplest version of all, no props needed, just you and your child breathing together. Because it uses touch and a shared rhythm, it works well for younger children or in the moment, once things are calm enough for closeness to feel safe.

How to do it

1. Breathe in slowly through the nose.
2. Breathe out slowly through the mouth.
3. Put one hand on your tummy, so you can feel it rise and fall.
4. Put your other hand near your mouth, like you're breathing gently into your own hand, feeling the warm air on your palm as you exhale.
5. Invite your child to copy you, hand on tummy, hand near mouth, and breathe together, in through the nose, out through the mouth.

This works because children co-regulate through watching and mirroring an adult's body, not through instructions. Doing it *with* your child, not just telling them to do it, is what makes it effective.

Grounding Techniques

Where breathing calms the body, grounding brings attention back to the present moment through the senses, useful once a child is calm enough to notice their surroundings again, or as a gentle check-in during the day.

5-4-3-2-1 Senses

Name, out loud or in your head:

5	things you can see
4	things you can hear
3	things you can touch
2	things you can smell
1	long, mindful breath

For younger children, simplify it, “find 3 things that are blue” or “name something for every letter, A, B, C...” works the same way, pulling attention outward and into the present.

Guided example: doing it together

Younger children often need the adult to model the first round, pointing out real things in the room rather than leaving it open-ended. A guided version might sound like this:

- **5 things you can see:** “Can you see the green leaf? Can you see the blue water in the picture? Can you see...”
- **4 things you can hear:** “Can you hear the fan? Can you hear the people chatting?”
- **3 things you can touch:** “Can you touch the carpet? Can you touch my finger?”
- **2 things you can smell:** “Can you smell the rubber? Can you smell your hair?”
- **1 long breath in:** finish together with one slow, shared breath.

Once a child has heard it modelled this way a few times, they'll usually start finding their own things to see, hear, and touch, the adult's job is just to go first.

Feet on the Floor

A very simple, always-available option: notice the feeling of feet flat on the floor, or hands resting on a table or lap. No words needed, just physical sensation, which can be easier to access than language in a stressed moment.

Building These Into Routine, Seamlessly

A technique nobody has practised is a technique that won't work under pressure. The goal isn't a special “calm down session”, it's weaving these into moments that already exist in the day.

- **Attach it to an existing routine:** one round of star breathing before bed, or breathing together in the car before walking into school, piggybacks on something that already happens daily.

- **Practise when calm, always:** the rumble stage is not the time to introduce something new. Calm, ordinary moments are.
- **Make it playful, not clinical:** decorating a paper star, choosing a “magic breathing hand”, these small touches make a child want to do it, rather than experience it as another instruction.
- **Model it yourself:** children learn regulation by watching an adult regulate, not by being told to. Breathing with your child, out loud, teaches far more than explaining the technique to them.
- **Keep it consistent across settings:** if a teacher and a parent are using the same technique with the same child, that's BRIDGE's G step in action, the same calming language and tools, wherever the child is.